

moonlighting as bartender at Mango (Tamarind Court) seven years ago. When the police round up the guests and frisk them for weapons, six are found to have guns on them. The lives and tales of these six suspects are re-traced, up to the moment of the fateful party.

If you read the novel to test your 'who's who' general knowledge, you are assured of a merry game. Ruby Gill, Vicky Rai and his father—home minister of Uttar Pradesh—aside, you have Arun Advani, an investigative journalist, Barkha Das, feisty and intrepid television personality, Mohan Kumar, a corrupt and womanising IAS officer, Shabnam Saxena, a Bollywood star, who is placed "at number 4 behind Aishwarya, Kareena and Priyanka", and a hive of other identifiable characters of the metros. So far so good.

The suspects' line-up—the Bureaucrat, the Actress, the Tribal, the Thief, the Politician and the American—is a warning that the tale may well be full of sound and fury, signifying nothing. The Bureaucrat is partly delusional (abstemious and moralistic when he believes he is 'Gandhi-Baba', and caressing his scotch and his mistress with equal fervour when he is not). The Actress rescues her double from a Bihar village and coaches the sly belle to impersonate her at public events. The Tribal is a near-naked native of the Andamans, climbing trees and houses with the aplomb of a monkey as he is searching for a shivling stolen from his tribe. The Thief is a mobile-phone-*chor* who steals the heart of Vicky Rai's beleaguered sister Ritu, while his cleft-lipped, blind, adopted sister Champi falls in love with, and is loved by, the Tribal from Andamans. The Politician wields a stately power which is mortgaged to his Guruji (of course). The American is an idiot tourist from Texas who flies to India to marry a penpal who sent him Shabnam's photograph and claimed the face for herself. I rest my case.

I must confess that I am hard put to find anything in this novel that can justify its length (550 pages) or its plot (sheer drivel) or its narrative style (nary a sparkle). It is neither Jessica Lal's story nor Manu Sharma's, but it shoots from the shoulder of that sensational case because it cannot carry the gun on its own. One can only hope that Aarushi Talwar is not the next literary victim. ■



**HIT WICKET:** The men in blue, without their lucky charm

## Fortune Rookie

**Cute butts, biteable chests. A saucy new read has all this and more.**



### THE ZOYA FACTOR

by ANUJA CHAUHAN

HarperCollins

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 509

■ **By Kaveree Bamzai**

It's a fascinating, unabashedly shallow world and I fell madly in love with it." That's the heroine talking about her profession, advertising, and that's how you feel after reading *The Zoya Factor*. All right, so it's for all of two minutes, but it's a pick-me-up that could beat even a movie-with-Patrick-Dempsey. In the time honoured tradition of Lauren Weisberger (so so) and Sophie Kinsella (super), first-time writer Anuja Chauhan traces the misadventures of Zoya Singh Solanki, who stumbles from a Shah Rukh Khan shoot to the ICC Champion's Trophy, from loser-in-love to the lucky charm of the Indian cricket team and snagger of cricket captain, the scrumptious Nikhil Khoda, who looks like a Boost ad and speaks like a Nike poster. Chauhan has an ear for dialogue and description, and it is tuned just right. The decor of a coffee shop in a Dhaka hotel is described as a mix of Mediterranean and Shantiniketan, a cricketer is said to have a Sanjay-Dutt-from-*Saajan* hairdo which women of a certain age will instantly get, and corny lines flow thick and fast (Nikhil Khoda *at gaya*,

Zimbabwe *ka phat gayaa*).

Ignore her larger comments on society (cricket is The Great Indian Disease) and her self-consciously outrageous comments (people tend to squeeze her chubby cheeks when all she really wants is for them to pinch her butt) and it is an airily enjoyable read. Cricket insiders will love the gentle lampooning of the whole cricket circus, the pushy agents, the starry players and the manipulative board. Several key characters are easy to recognise—the curly haired heartthrob Zahid Pathan, the flirtatious hairy Hharviindar Singh, the ever-busy ponytailed adman PPK and the crafty IBCC president Jagpal Lohia.

If you're wondering at the bubbly prose, it comes as no surprise that the author has worked on several key Pepsi campaigns. Clearly all that fizz has rubbed off on her writing. And yes, we know chick lit is nothing but *Mills & Boon* with less racy covers (though there's quite a lot of heavy breathing and close dancing in this one to justify a *nangu-pangu* cover), but hey, who's complaining? Think of all the steely gazes, sculpted toffee chests and biteable butts to drown in. Only problem? At 509 pages, it's way too long for short attention spanners and the Lingnath Babas and Rinku Chachis are needless distractions. Advice to reader looking for a quickie: lose those parts and dive straight in to the delectable Khoda. ■